Denglisch

Speaking script · 14 slides · about 10 minutes · 4 speakers

WHO	SLIDES	TIME	GERMAN TO SAY
Max	slides 1–3 and 9–10	about 4 min	all the German
Speaker 2	slides 4–6	about 2½ min	a few words — hints included
Speaker 3	slides 7–8	about 2½ min	only “Handy”
Speaker 4	slides 11–14	about 2½ min	a few words — hints included

> **Normal text** is what you say. Put it in your own words if you like.
>
> **Yellow boxes** are not spoken: they tell you what to do, or how to pronounce a German word.
>
> **HAND OVER** marks where the next person takes over.
>
> Each speaker starts on a new page, so you can print only your own part.

Max

SLIDES 1–3 AND 9–10

1 Title

Hello everyone. Our topic is Denglisch — that is German plus English.

We want to show you how English is changing the German language, and ask one question: is that making German better, or worse?

2 A normal German sentence

Let me read you a normal German sentence. You probably don't speak German — but let's see how much you understand.

> (read the sentence slowly)

How many words did you understand?

> (let them count, then click the sentence)

Eight English words in three short sentences: meeting, team, check, e-mails, download, files, shopping — and Handy.

And one of them is not even real English. We will come back to that.

3 How young Germans actually talk

And this is what Denglisch sounds like among young people — in the school yard, on the bus, in group chats.

"Das ist so cringe." "Ich bin komplett lost." "Actually hab ich keine Zeit."

Nobody translates anything. The English word doesn't even get a new meaning. It is just dropped into the middle of a German sentence.

(HAND OVER TO SPEAKER 2)

9 Words German already had

The second argument: many English words replace German words that already existed.

Germans say "Meeting" — but there is a German word for it: Besprechung. Feedback — Rückmeldung. Event — Veranstaltung.

These English words don't fill a gap. Often they are used just because English sounds more modern.

10 Even Germans don't know how to say it

And the third argument: English words don't fit German grammar.

Here is a normal sentence: "Ich habe die Datei …" — "I have … the file." Downloaded. But which form is correct? Let's vote.

> (read the three forms, hands up for each one, then click them)

The Duden — the official German dictionary — says "downgeloadet". But in real German texts, about one in three people write "gedownloadet". Germans simply don't agree.

And it is the same with many other words, like liken or updaten.

(HAND OVER TO SPEAKER 4)

Speaker 2

SLIDES 4–6

4 Almost every second European speaks English

So why is there so much English in German? Because English is the language Europe uses to talk to itself.

When a German, a Spaniard and a Pole meet, they speak English.

Almost half of the people in the EU can have a conversation in English — 47 out of 100.

And among young people, it is 70 out of 100. That is why Denglisch is strongest among young people.

5 Three ways English gets into German

English gets into German in three ways.

First: words that are taken as they are — the meeting, the team, the job. The word stays the same. It just gets a German article: der, die or das.

Second: an English word with German grammar — downloaden, chillen, googeln. The word is English, the grammar around it is German.

Third: fake English. Words that look English — but no English speaker uses them like that. We will test you on those in a minute.

> (das Meeting [dass MEE-ting] · das Team [dass TEEM] · der Job [dair JOB] · der, die, das [dair, dee, dass] · downloaden [DOWN-loh-den] · chillen [CHIL-len] · googeln [GOO-geln])

6 Germany's Youth Word of the Year

Every year Germany picks a youth word of the year.

From 2008 to 2018, a jury chose the winner. Only 4 of 11 were English.

Since 2020, young people vote themselves. And look what happens: lost, cringe, smash, goofy — 6 of the last 7 winners are English.

The winner in 2025 was "das crazy" — the English word "crazy" with the German article "das".

And this year, 2026, the winner is "ragebait".

> (the two dashed ones, Babo and Aura, come from other languages — that is why they are not yellow)

> (das crazy [dass CRAZY])

(HAND OVER TO SPEAKER 3)

Speaker 3

SLIDES 7–8

7 Quiz: fake English

Remember the third kind of Denglisch — fake English? These words look English, and Germans use them every day. But what do Germans mean by them? Guess first.

> (let them guess each word, then click it)

Handy — Germans mean a mobile phone. In English, "handy" just means useful. Sounds familiar? We will come back to that at the end.

Beamer — a projector. In English, it is slang for a BMW.

Public Viewing — watching football together on a big screen. In English, it means looking at a dead body before a funeral. So if a German invites you to a public viewing: bring a football, not flowers.

Oldtimer — a vintage car. In English, an old person.

Home Office — working from home. In Britain, the Home Office is the ministry for police and borders.

Smoking — a tuxedo. In English, just smoking a cigarette.

> (short on time: only Handy, Public Viewing and Smoking)

> (Handy [HEN-dee])

8 Come in and find out

So — is all this making German worse? There are good arguments for yes.

The first one: not everybody understands English.

Douglas, a big German perfume shop, used the slogan "Come in and find out". In a study in 2003, many Germans understood it as: "Come in — and find your way back out." Not exactly what Douglas wanted.

Not everyone in Germany speaks English. And if people don't understand it, Denglisch doesn't bring people together — it shuts them out.

(HAND OVER TO MAX)

Speaker 4

SLIDES 11–14

11 Sometimes English is simply the better word

But there is another side.

First: new things need names. Smartphone, laptop, podcast, streaming — German never had its own words for these.

Second: English is short and international. Team, job, online, okay — the same word works in Berlin, in Paris and in Seoul.

Third: German makes English its own. Handyvertrag — a phone contract. Teamleiter — a team leader. The English parts become part of German words and German grammar.

And this is not new. Balkon and Toilette came from French 300 years ago. Today nobody notices.

> (Handyvertrag [HEN-dee-fer-trahk] · Teamleiter [TEEM-ly-ter] · Balkon [bal-KONG] · Toilette [twa-LET-te])

12 Our answer

So — better or worse? Our answer: neither. It is change.

It is worse when people don't understand it, or when English replaces a German word for no reason.

It is better when it names something new, like computer or internet. When it helps Germans talk to the rest of Europe. And when Germans get creative with it — like Handy or Beamer.

German isn't dying. It does what it always did: it takes words and makes them German.

13 Your turn

And now you. Germans call a mobile phone "Handy". In Korea you say 핸드폰 — hand phone.

Two countries, two made-up English words for the same thing. And neither one is used in the UK or the US.

So — is English making German better or worse? And what about Korean?

Hands up: who thinks better? Worse? Neither?

Thank you.

14 Sources

Nothing to say. Leave it on screen during the questions.